Chad Lickfelt

International Relations · humanitarian policy, democratic erosion, disability-inclusive humanitarian action

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PROFILE

Undergraduate International Relations student at Florida International University working at the intersection of humanitarian policy, political analysis, and disability inclusion. Author of an independent research paper on Sudan's informal economic systems and builder of the Democratic Erosion Observatory, a source-backed quarterly index scoring democratic health across a comparative set of countries. Writes analytical essays on democratic backsliding and humanitarian policy for a growing readership. Seeking research, analysis, and policy roles with humanitarian and international organizations.

RESEARCH & INDEPENDENT PROJECTS

Democratic Erosion Observatory

2026 – present

Independent longitudinal index · Founder and sole analyst

- Designed and built a quarterly monitoring framework scoring six indicators of democratic health (electoral integrity, judicial independence, executive constraint, civil society space, press and media freedom, chilling effect and self-censorship) on a 0–4 ordinal rubric, with every score tied to written rationale and a linked source library.
- Authored the methodology, including a 30-cell scoring rubric and codified de-confliction, quiescence, and saturation rules to keep scores comparable across countries and cycles.
- Completed Q1 and Q2 2026 scoring cycles across the United States, Hungary, Poland, Turkey, and Russia within an eight-country comparative frame. Designed an event-based early-warning register that logs discrete erosion attempts separately from the quarterly index.
- Publishes the results as analytical essays, including a comparative reading of the United States and Hungary reaching identical composite scores from opposite directions.

Parallel Economies: The Resilience of Sudan's Informal Economic Systems During Humanitarian Intervention, 1983–1993

Fall 2025

Independent research paper · Florida International University

- Examined how hawala remittance networks, sanduk savings associations, and suq markets functioned as parallel economic infrastructure through a decade of civil war, famine, and state contraction.
- Argued that these informal systems were durable institutions rather than stopgaps, and that humanitarian actors should build on existing local systems in protracted crises instead of displacing them.
- Full text available at chadlickfelt.com.

Humanitarian News Aggregator

2025

Personal project

- Built an HTML-based dashboard aggregating crisis reporting from ReliefWeb, UN OCHA, UNHCR, ICRC, MSF, and WFP to track humanitarian developments across organizations in one view.

EDUCATION

Florida International University

Expected 2028

B.A., International Relations · Fully online program

- Relevant coursework: African Politics, International Political Economy, European Politics, French.

Prior coursework

2011 – 2019

- Valencia College, Peace and Justice / Conflict Studies (2019).
- Spring Arbor University, 48 credits in Sociology and Criminal Justice (2011–2014).

WRITING

Analytical essays on democratic erosion and humanitarian policy

Substack · 2025 – present

- Regular long-form pieces on institutional erosion in the United States and Europe, humanitarian policy, and the politics of state institutions, drawing on the Observatory's data. Selected titles: "Hungary Is Climbing Out. America Is Sliding In.", "The Supreme Crime", "The Party Left the Building", "The Canaries Are Going Quiet".

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT & AFFILIATIONS

- Certification track in progress: disability-inclusive disaster risk reduction and Core Humanitarian Standard.
- Member, Chatham House (Royal Institute of International Affairs).
- Member, Chicago Council on Global Affairs.
- Professional network of 2,300+ contacts across UN agencies, international NGOs, think tanks, and the humanitarian sector.

WORK & VOLUNTEER EXPERIENCE

Administrative Assistant, Global Admissions (Student Worker)

2011 – 2013

Spring Arbor University

- Supported international student recruitment and admissions; managed communications with prospective students, staff, and faculty; conducted research and maintained recruitment tracking data.
- Classroom volunteer, Partin Settlement Elementary School (2019–2022).
- Youth program volunteer, Concord United Methodist Church Teen Center (2010–2014).
- Member, Youth Advisory Committee, Jackson Community Foundation, reviewing grant applications (2008–2009).

SKILLS

Research and analysis: policy research, indicator and rubric design, structured source documentation, academic and analytical writing, literature review.

Regional and thematic focus: Sudan and the Horn of Africa; democratic erosion in the United States and Central Europe; disability-inclusive humanitarian action; informal economies in fragile states.

Technical: Notion (relational research databases), HTML and CSS, GitHub Pages, Microsoft Office, Substack.

Languages: English (native); French (beginner, in progress).